



GDD 01

Feelings Friends

Name it, and it gets smaller

The very first node, and the base for everything, retrofitted to the mechanic-embodying standard. Children name feelings on friendly faces, learn every feeling is okay, calm the big ones, help others, and practise their big "no". Seven mechanics, thirty real-choice moments, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

Name it, and it gets smaller.

Feelings Friends is the very first node in SwipeEd, and the foundation the whole app stands on: naming emotions and saying "no". Children meet a cast of Feelings Friends, name what they (and others) feel, learn that every feeling is okay, build calming strategies, and rehearse their big "no" and asking for help. This is the v2 retrofit: the v1 library was rich in SEL ideas but 100% binary taps with no real choices; the same warm content now arrives through seven play actions with thirty branch/role-play moments.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g01 · feelings (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 1 · ages 3-6 · light canvas · parent co-played
Thread / topics	C · Feelings & Life Skills · UNESCO 5.2, 5.3, 5.6 (emotions)
Prerequisite / builds on	None, this is the first node in the app.
Gating	Core · "the base for everything".
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS retrofit from v1 (was 100% binary, 0 autonomy).

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

30

real-choice moves

8

myths busted

0%

binary taps

Permission to feel.

From the Chapter 1 personas. As the first node, it sets the emotional tone for everything, and gives every child language and permission for their feelings.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Aria, 5 ("good girls don't get angry")	Permission for "no" and big feelings, no buzzer.	strike-rewrite + role-play : erase the myth, say it.
Vihaan, 4 ("big boys don't cry")	That all feelings, and tears, are for him too.	strike-rewrite + branch : feel it, choose a calm action.
Kabir, 5 (audio-first)	Voiced naming and calming he can say aloud.	role-play : "I feel ____", breathe with Lensy.
Megha (parent, "no dopamine machine")	Real SEL that sparks a conversation.	Co-play reflects; a feelings check-in to share.
Every child	The base skill: name it, calm it, ask for help.	match + build : faces, calm-down kit.

Why this works (the evidence). Affect labelling, "name it to tame it", reduces the intensity of big feelings, and naming emotions is a foundational SEL skill (CASEL). Young children learn emotions through faces, story, voice and doing, so the game makes the child name, say and do, not tap a quiz.

Seven moves, one heart.

The rework's heart: the SEL skills arrive through seven actions, each one being the lesson. Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE CHILD DOES	EMBODIES	N
reflect	Checks in on their own feeling (no wrong answer).	Emotional awareness.	18
branch	Chooses what to do with a feeling (and sees the result).	Feeling vs action; regulation.	16
role-play (voice)	Names it aloud, breathes, says the big "no".	Affect labelling; assertion.	14
match	Pairs face/body-clue to the feeling.	Reading emotions.	11
sort	Sorts feeling vs action, calmer vs not.	Telling concepts apart.	10
strike-rewrite	Erases a feelings myth, writes the truth.	Conceptual change.	8
build	Builds a calm-down kit / feelings face / breath.	Strategies, made concrete.	7

30 of 84 moments are branch or role-play, the most of any game, because feelings are learned by doing and saying. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

The two-test, passed.

Is it fun?

The Feelings Friends are a warm little cast: name their faces, breathe with Lensy (smell the flower, blow the candle), build a calm-down kit, cheer yourself for handling a big feeling. It's gentle, personal and a bit story-like, the safe-to-be-wrong tone Aria needs, with a different action on every screen.

Is it teaching?

Yes, the foundational SEL curriculum: naming feelings (affect labelling), that all feelings are okay while actions are a choice, calming strategies, empathy for others, and the big "no" plus asking a trusted grown-up for help, the base every later chapter builds on.

The belief it moves. From "big boys don't cry; good girls don't get angry; some feelings are bad; asking for help is weak" → "all feelings are okay, naming one makes it smaller, I can calm big feelings, and saying no and asking for help are brave."

Same heart, new actions.

84 scenarios across six categories, grounded in affect-labelling and CASEL-aligned SEL. Every one re-encoded to a typed v2 mechanic.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
Naming & recognising feelings	14	match, reflect, role-play	Faces, body-clues, more than one at once, feeling vs action.
All feelings are okay	12	strike-rewrite, branch, sort	Boys cry, girls get angry, jealousy/fear okay; action is the choice.
Calming big feelings	12	role-play, build, branch	Breaths, calm-down kit, ask for a break, calm corner.
Reading & helping others	13	branch, match, role-play	Notice faces; comfort; include; share joy; "me too".
Saying no & asking for help	13	role-play, branch, build	Big "no"; tell a trusted grown-up; asking help is brave.
My feelings & my friends	14	reflect, build, role-play	Check-ins; feelings pass; self-kindness; the daily greeting.

A branch scenario (feeling vs action), verbatim.

hook: "You feel really angry because someone broke your tower."
 option A "Say 'I'm angry!' and take big breaths" -> the anger shrinks; nobody hurt [best]
 option B "Hit the other kid" -> someone's hurt and you feel worse
 debrief: "The feeling is okay; the action is your choice. Breathe, don't hit."

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 01 Feelings Friends — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game erases.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
Big boys don't cry.	Everyone cries; crying lets big feelings out.	Emotional health.
Good girls don't get angry.	Anger is okay; what matters is what you do with it.	Emotional health.
Some feelings are bad feelings.	There are no bad feelings; only kind or unkind actions.	Emotion validation.
Feeling scared is babyish.	Everyone feels scared; it's normal and okay.	Emotion validation.
You should hide your feelings.	Sharing feelings with someone you trust helps.	Emotion expression.
Asking for help means you're weak.	Asking for help is smart and brave.	Help-seeking.
You shouldn't bother grown-ups with feelings.	Trusted grown-ups want to help.	Help-seeking.
Some feelings should never be shown.	All feelings can be shown in kind, safe ways.	Emotion expression.

The micro-loop.

1. **Hook.** Lensy: "the Feelings Friends are here, who shall we meet?".
2. **Play.** One of seven mechanics, rotated, never the same twice in a row.
3. **Settle.** Naming or breathing visibly shrinks the big feeling, the "name it to tame it" payoff.
4. **UN → RE moment.** On a myth, UN erases it and RE writes the truth ("big boys don't cry" → "everyone cries").
5. **Apply.** Say it, breathe it, help a friend, or check in on yourself.
6. **Sticker.** The Feelings Friend badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surfaces: the **feelings faces** (name & make them), the **breathe-with-Lensy** calmer, and the **calm-down kit** builder. Safe-to-be-wrong throughout (a misread face gently re-asks); audio-first for non-readers.

Gentle, safe, validating.

- **Register.** Ages 3-6: warm, calm, story-like; the feeling is "all of me is welcome here".
- **No WRONG buzzer.** Aria's fear is designed out, misreads become a gentle next question; reflects have no wrong answer.
- **All feelings valid.** Never shames a feeling; separates feeling (always okay) from action (a kind choice).
- **Both directions.** Frees boys to cry and girls to be angry; emotional range is for everyone.
- **Safety hand-off.** The big "no" and "tell a trusted grown-up" connect to My Body, My Rules and Safety Squad.
- **Access.** Audio-first and voiced, offline, calm-mode, colour never the only signal; co-play; India names & contexts.

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. feelings** — node.game === GameDone key === registry id (note: id is "feelings", not "feelings-friends"; confirm in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema.** Each scenario carries type + typed payload (match.pairs, strike-rewrite.myth, role-play.yourLine, branch.options, build.pieces/sequence, sort.items/bins/key, reflect.options). Reuses the shared templates from g09.
- **Scorecard-gated.** Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, max 21%, 0% binary, 30 autonomy, 8 UN→RE, 5 personas, 100% completeness). The gate caught a low UN→RE count on first pass and was fixed before delivery.
- **Foundational vocabulary.** Establishes feeling-words, "name it to tame it", calmers and the big "no" that later nodes reuse; keep stable.
- **Generated path.** Label/order/thread changes flow through the xlsx + gen-path, never hand-edited path.ts.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): no WRONG buzzer; all feelings valid; feeling vs action; both directions (boys cry, girls anger); safety hand-off; audio-first; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Name it to tame it.** Affect labelling, putting feelings into words, reduces their intensity; naming emotions is a foundational, CASEL-aligned SEL skill, and the base for self-regulation.
- **Young children learn feelings by doing.** 3-6s build emotional skills through faces, story, voice and practice (breathing, saying it), not through being told, which is why this game makes the child name, say and breathe.
- **All feelings valid; actions are the choice.** Validating every feeling while teaching kind actions, plus calming strategies and help-seeking, builds lifelong emotional regulation, and frees children from "boys don't cry / girls don't get angry".

Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. Retrofit 7 of 9 (g01-08, g37) to the v2 standard. g01 done; remaining: g02 (Ch.1) and g08 (Ch.2).